balance though, there is nothing intrinsically wrong about the Agnipath Scheme, which was announced on 14 June 2022 by the RM, with the Chiefs in attendance.[6] HR policies are always reviewed periodically and are subject to change. The announcement of the scheme generated some vociferous debates. I was approached by a number of persons and TV channels to give out my views. To each one, I replied that the Chief, General Manoj Pande, was more than competent to respond to any queries, and my stepping in would seem like a calling-in of reinforcements. I also reminded all the media persons of my intention, which I had conveyed to them on my retirement, that I would not give my comments or interviews on any service matter for six months post-retirement. I stuck to my promise and the media, too, respected my wishes. However, I did write an article on the Agniveer scheme sometime later, after the dust of the initial announcement had settled down, highlighting the advantages of the scheme and what more needed to be done, which was published in *The Hindu* in November 2022.[7]

Gender Equality

On 17 February 2020, the Supreme Court of India passed its final judgment on the case *The Secretary, Ministry of Defence v. Ms Babita Puniya & Ors*, on the subject of grant of Permanent Commission (PC) to Women Officers, ruling in favour of the respondents (women officers), bringing the curtain down on a case that had lingered on for seventeen years. In February 2003, Babita Puniya, an advocate, instituted a writ petition in the nature of a public interest litigation before the Delhi High Court for the grant of PC to women SSC Officers in the Army.[8] The Union of India was represented by R Balasubramanian,

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